

How far is it possible for the education system of your country to balance national needs with individual interests and aspirations?

📖 This essay question requires the student to go beyond a mere description of a country's needs (political, economic and social in nature), and the individual's interests and aspirations. A good answer such as the one printed below would recognise the false dichotomy between the former and the latter; while it is true that the two can conflict, they can also overlap in certain circumstances.

- ♦ Isaac begins his essay with a clear position. This stance is maintained and circumspectly qualified throughout.
- ♦ There are numerous examples of felicitous expression in this essay. Generally, the language employed by the writer is incisive and assertive, which adds to the effectiveness of his analysis.
- ♦ The use of clear topic sentences and useful connectors makes this a well-structured essay. However, examples are limited to the Direct School Admission system, the Singapore Sports School and the School of The Arts. The writer could have included a wider range of examples to show how individual aspirations can be achieved within the national education framework.

Like many high-performing school systems, Singapore's education system, which is widely lauded as one of the world's finest, is often subject to scrutiny; mainly, it has been [1] derided as oppressive and stifling. As a burgeoning young nation, Singapore has had to use its education system to produce its most vital resource – manpower to serve its economic needs. Consequently, many have [2] condemned the system for neglecting individual aspirations and interests for collective success. While having some level of veracity, such a claim does not paint an accurate picture of Singapore education. [3] Ultimately, Singapore's primary national needs – a functional workforce and patriotic populace – do not conflict with individual aspirations in the education system. At times, Singapore's collective goals even coincide with individual ambitions and passions, with the system going so far as to augment the pursuit of personal goals.

One of Singapore's defining characteristics is that of intense pragmatism. Nonetheless, in the Singapore system, the pursuit of improving Singapore's competitiveness does not fundamentally contradict the personal journey to fulfill one's dreams. In remaining economically viable, Singapore has deeply ingrained the idea of practicality into the education system. [4] On a cultural level, a Singaporean education means an immersion into a pressure-cooker of a learning journey,

[1] and [2]. The writer judiciously chooses words like "derided", "oppressive", "stifling", "condemned" and "neglecting", all of which capture the criticisms that have been levelled at his country's education system. He is careful, however, not to identify too closely with them, i.e. by explaining that they were driven by economic concerns and insisting that these views do not accurately depict the entire education system.

[3] The writer offers a clear thesis statement (with elaboration) that explains why, contrary to popular belief, national needs and individual aspirations need not clash.

[4] and [5] Analysing trends on both the cultural and institutional levels is a systematic way of giving more scope to his discussion.

with industriousness and achievement being the foremost virtues desired of a student. [5] On an institutional level, the system is geared towards optimal performance – Singapore schools provide vigorous programmes and curriculum to allow students to succeed in examinations, their primary performance indicator. With such an emphasis on functionality both at the grassroots of society and coming from governing bodies, [6] some fear that the Singapore student has no choice but to leave personal interest aside to fulfill an ostensible duty to succeed as achieving students. Indubitably, a focus on practical, functional pursuits as a primary occupation of time does reduce the overall potential for personal pursuits to be explored. [7] Nevertheless, it can be said that a high level of balance is reached. [8] Obviously, the Singaporean student needs to devote much of his time to practical academic pursuits. On the other hand, the system also provides one with considerable opportunity – through extra-curricular activities, overseas exchanges and other school-based programmes – to select and pursue activities that may not be immediately useful to material success. [9] In fact, the system increasingly recognizes and values the ability to strike a balance between practical, academic pursuits directly useful to the national need of a competitive workforce with the commitment to a personal passion; scholarships and programmes like the Direct School Admission scheme increasingly promote not the prioritization of utilitarian pursuits over personal inclinations, but rather a reasoned, healthy balance between the two. [10] Overall, the national need for a competitive, economically-empowered people and personal needs can be said to co-exist in the education system.

Another arguable national need is ideological in nature. As a young nation still looking to find its place in a volatile world, Singapore has had to place great ideological emphasis on loyalty and patriotism. [11] It is often argued, however, that the need to educate our young with constant attention on the goal of nurturing a loyal population can stifle individual aspirations. [12] Some say that the focus on a fixed set of values seen as politically valuable – such as patriotism, racial harmony and the importance of collective goals – make for a rigid socio-cultural mind-set. The fear that a personal pursuit could be in contravention with a national ideal is real; overseas trips are undertaken with a view to improve students' sense of rootedness to Singapore, and themes directly relevant to nation-building are also imbued into

[6] The writer astutely uses the phrase "some fear that" to present an alternative perspective, hence adding balance to his essay.

[7], [8], [9] and [10] The writer acknowledges that Singapore is still largely a pragmatic society with utilitarian considerations that form the basis for many decisions. The signal words and phrases "nevertheless", "obviously", "in fact" and "overall" help to guide the reader along as the writer continuously links and builds his arguments into a coherent whole.

[11], [12] and [13] The writer signals his consideration of alternative perspectives by including phrases such as "it is often argued", "some say" and "as many critics say".

academic curricula and students' experiences with the arts. Nonetheless, the constant attention on the national need for ideological loyalty does not necessarily serve as a replacement for one's own aspirations [13] as many critics may say. Instead, in Singapore, it is merely presented as a guiding direction for one's personal pursuits rather than a mould for it. Love for a sport or passion for an academic field hardly contradicts the need to serve the nation. Rather, it is this need that reminds people to direct the results and energy from their pursuits to a larger purpose. As such, we can see that Singapore's national needs can be balanced with personal aspirations – the former forms an overarching ideal within which the latter is free to develop.

Finally, national needs do not just co-exist with personal aspirations – they can often coincide in the Singapore system. Having moved away from its initial turbulent years, the Singapore system also [14] actively promotes the pursuit of individual passion as a means to achieve the national goal of fostering a driven, vibrant society. The education system has actually been moving towards institutionalising the support for individual pursuits. Apart from schools that develop what are mainly conventional academic preferences seen as useful but not necessarily as personal interests, the Singapore system also allows for schools like the School of the Arts and the Singapore Sports School that appeal to what are more commonly seen as individual sources of interest. In these cases, individual athletics and aesthetic aspirations are perfectly in line with national needs for a stronger sporting culture and a more diverse arts scene. Additionally, [15] the attainment of achievements seemingly more relevant to national needs can, in fact, serve as a platform to gain opportunities to pursue personal interests. Striving for a place in a good school or working towards better results are commonly associated with the national needs for competitiveness and achievement. When applied in the system, however, they can serve a further purpose to open new doors to individual pursuits. Achievements like entering a good school often entail access to better freedom and opportunities for co-curricular activities, along with other useful opportunities for personal growth. Evidently, in the Singapore system, personal goals and pursuits often associated with the fulfillment of national needs can even boast a complementary, symbiotic relationship at times.

[14] The writer continues to argue that national needs and personal aspirations are not mutually exclusive. To this end, he provides two well-reasoned examples, i.e. the Singapore Sports School and the School of the Arts.

[15] Here, the writer continues to debunk the misconception that national interests and personal needs are necessarily at odds. Although he has a tendency to write fairly long content paragraphs, clarity is not compromised because of his analytical skills and language proficiency.

[16] As a whole, Singapore has done a relatively

commendable job at balancing national needs and individual interests. The tangible activities, policies and cultural values associated with the two can co-exist; the national needs for an economically viable workforce is tempered with a similarly strong host of opportunities to explore personal passions, while the need for a patriotic society serves as a direction for personal pursuits rather than an alternative. Ultimately, as Singapore progresses and adapts to a changing world position and cultural climate, it is also moving towards not just balancing but integrating the collective and personal goals of its people, manifesting itself in an education system to increasingly support both this and aforementioned goals in tandem.

[16] Once again, the writer reminds the reader that it is possible to negotiate individual needs with pragmatic concerns.